

East Timor

Ratio: 2:3 **Adopted:** May 20, 2002 **Usage:** National and Civil

*Black represents the
oppression of the past*

*The white star
symbolizes hope*



*Red stands for the
struggle for national
liberation*

*Yellow represents the
wealth of the country*

Asia



East Timor voted for independence from Indonesia in 1999. A UN administration was in place until official independence on May 20, 2002.

At midnight on May 19, 2002, the UN flag was removed from outside the government offices in Dili, the capital. The new country, now officially recognized as a national state, has its own parliament, its own president, and its own flag.

NEW STATE, OLD FLAG

The flag illustrated above is actually the flag designed by the Fretilin party for the “Democratic Republic of Timor” in 1975, following the transition from Portuguese colony to independence. However, the infant nation’s subsequent invasion and occupation by Indonesia led to the adoption of that country’s flag for the last quarter of the twentieth century.

SYMBOLISM OF THE FLAG

The black triangle represents the darkness of four centuries of colonial oppression under the Portuguese. The golden-yellow arrowhead recalls the long struggle for independence, as well as the hope of the country’s future prosperity. The red field reflects the blood shed by the Timorese people on their journey toward autonomy—a symbol which has taken on greater poignancy since the referendum for independence and the massacre of thousands of East Timorese by pro-Indonesian militias in 1999. The white of the star symbolizes peace, while the star itself represents the guiding light which gives hope for the future.